

ECCLESIA DISCIPLESHIP & COMMISSIONING

EDC 108: ETHICS AND CHRISTIAN CHARACTER

Part One:

The Biblical and Theological Foundation of Christian Ethics

Introduction: Why Ethics and Character Matter

Christian ethics and character are not optional adornments for the believer; they are the visible expression of the inner work of Christ in a person's life. Salvation and discipleship begin in the heart, but they must manifest outwardly through ethical behavior and godly character. Jesus' teaching consistently links obedience to God with ethical living. The Sermon on the Mount, for instance, opens with blessings that describe not ritualistic religion but transformative character traits: humility, mercy, purity of heart, and peacemaking (Matthew 5:3–12). Ethics, therefore, is not merely about rules; it is about the formation of Christlike character and the practical outworking of love in every dimension of life.

Biblical Definition of Ethics and Character

In Scripture, ethics is inseparable from character. It is the practice of living rightly before God and others, rooted in a heart transformed by the Spirit. Paul emphasizes this in Galatians 5:22–23, describing the fruit of the Spirit: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. These are not abstract ideals but practical evidence of God's work in the believer, guiding decisions, actions, and relationships.

Christian character flows from the knowledge of God, reverence for His Word, and obedience to His commands. Proverbs 4:23 underscores this link: *"Keep your heart with all diligence, for out of it spring the issues of life."* Ethics is therefore both rooted and relational: rooted in God's character and relational in its expression toward others.

Theological Foundations of Christian Ethics

Christian ethics finds its ultimate grounding in the nature and will of God. God is holy, righteous, and loving, and He calls His people to reflect His character in all aspects of life. The Decalogue (Exodus 20) and the teachings of Jesus in the Gospels provide concrete expression of this ethical expectation.

Ethics is also Christocentric. Jesus summarized the Law and the Prophets as love for God and love for neighbour (Matthew 22:37–40). This principle demonstrates that Christian ethics is not merely rule-following, but a reflection of the relational priorities of God. It is both vertical, in devotion to God, and horizontal, in conduct toward others.

Paul reinforces this theological foundation in Romans 12:1–2, urging believers to

present their bodies as living sacrifices and to be transformed by the renewing of the mind. Christian character, therefore, is the visible manifestation of internal renewal through the Spirit, aligning every thought, word, and deed with God's moral and ethical purposes.

The Role of Character in Discipleship

Character is the essential measure of discipleship. Jesus' call to discipleship includes both obedience and transformation: "*If you love Me, keep My commandments*" (John 14:15). Christian character is developed through deliberate practice of spiritual disciplines, commitment to holiness, and intentional engagement with Scripture.

Ethics and character also serve as witness to the world. Paul declares that believers are "*a letter from Christ, known and read by all men*" (2 Corinthians 3:2). The credibility of the Gospel is closely tied to the ethical consistency of its witnesses. A disciple with strong Christian character embodies God's justice, mercy, and integrity in ways that inspire trust and advance the Kingdom.

The Formation of Ethical Character

The formation of Christian character is both progressive and Spirit-driven. Scripture portrays this as a lifelong journey. Believers are called to put off the old nature and put on the new man (Ephesians 4:22–24). This involves deliberate effort in several areas:

- Moral Awareness: Understanding right and wrong according to God's Word (Psalm 119:105).
- Self-Examination: Testing motives and actions continually (2 Corinthians 13:5).
- Discipline and Accountability: Engaging in practices that cultivate virtue and resist vice (1 Timothy 4:7–8).
- Service and Sacrifice: Acting ethically even when inconvenient, modeling Christ's selflessness (Philippians 2:3–8).

Ethical character is not abstract knowledge; it is habitual righteousness that shapes the believer's responses, decisions, and relationships.

Biblical Examples of Christian Character

The Bible provides abundant models of ethical living and Christlike character:

- Joseph: Exemplifies integrity, moral courage, and faithfulness under testing (Genesis 39).
- Daniel: Demonstrates obedience to God above cultural pressure, combined with wisdom and discernment (Daniel 6).
- Jesus Christ: Perfectly embodies the union of holiness, love, humility, and justice, serving as the ultimate ethical standard (Matthew 5–7; Philippians 2:5–8).
- Paul: His letters show ongoing growth in character, ethics, and spiritual maturity, modeling the practical outworking of discipleship (2 Corinthians 12:7–10).

These examples underscore that Christian character is tested, refined, and proven through adversity, obedience, and faithfulness.

Ethics in Community and Leadership

Christian ethics and character are especially critical in leadership. Scripture warns that leaders must be above reproach, demonstrating integrity, humility, and diligence (1 Timothy 3:2–7; Titus 1:6–9). Ethical lapses in leadership can undermine ministry effectiveness and damage the witness of the Church.

Moreover, in the community of faith, ethical behavior strengthens trust, unity, and accountability. Galatians 6:1–2 calls believers to restore those caught in sin gently, reflecting a combination of truth, mercy, and personal integrity. Christian character thus ensures that leadership and communal life reflect God’s justice, love, and faithfulness.

Challenges to Ethical Living

Believers face consistent challenges to ethical and godly living, including:

- Cultural pressures: Societal norms may conflict with biblical morality (Romans 12:2).
- Temptation of power and pride: Even spiritual leaders must guard against self-exaltation (1 Peter 5:5–6).
- Internal struggles: The tension between the flesh and Spirit requires continuous reliance on God (Galatians 5:17).

The response is rooted in Scripture, prayer, accountability, and the ongoing work of the Spirit. Ethics and character are developed not in isolation, but in the context of disciplined, Spirit-led life.

Part Two: Practical Formation, Strategies, and Application

Practical Formation of Christian Character

Christian character is formed through deliberate and consistent practices, not passive belief. Scripture emphasizes that ethical living and holiness require both intentionality and reliance on God. Paul exhorts believers to put on the “new man” and actively cultivate virtues: *“Put on the new self, created to be like God in true righteousness and holiness”* (Ephesians 4:24).

Practical formation involves internal and external dimensions. Internally, the believer must engage the mind, heart, and conscience through Scripture, prayer, and meditation. Externally, ethical practice is reflected in relationships, decisions, and service to others.

The daily rhythm of discipleship shapes character are:

Prayer and Dependence: Ethical behavior begins in the heart, guided by the Spirit. Prayer cultivates humility, discernment, and reliance on God's guidance (Philippians 4:6–7). Regular confession and repentance maintain integrity before God and others (1 John 1:9).

Scriptural Meditation and Application: Knowledge of God's Word is necessary but insufficient; it must be applied in daily life (James 1:22–25). Meditating on principles of honesty, justice, mercy, and love forms decision-making aligned with God's character.

Service and Sacrificial Living: Ethics is practiced in action. Serving others cultivates humility, combats selfishness, and trains believers to reflect Christ's selfless love (Mark 10:43–45). Ethical formation requires active engagement, not passive reflection.

Accountability and Community: Community enforces discipline and integrity. Proverbs 27:17 emphasizes mutual sharpening. Mentors, peers, and leaders help discern blind spots and reinforce ethical standards. Within EDC, accountability structures are designed to integrate instruction, supervision, and relational correction, ensuring discipleship is both formative and protective.

Christian character faces both internal and external pressures:

Internal Struggles: The flesh and sinful tendencies resist ethical living (Galatians 5:17). Spiritual disciplines such as prayer, fasting, and Scripture meditation cultivate self-control, patience, and moral discernment.

External Pressures: Cultural norms, materialism, and peer influence often challenge biblical ethics (Romans 12:2). The disciple must actively discern, sometimes counterculturally, to maintain integrity.

Spiritual Warfare: Satan targets leaders and disciples for compromise (Ephesians 6:12). Ethical vigilance requires spiritual awareness, daily reliance on God, and consistent obedience.

Overcoming these obstacles requires intentionality, relational support, and Spirit-led vigilance, ensuring that character is shaped not by convenience but by conviction.

Integration with Other Level 1 Foundations

Ethics and character are inseparable from other Level 1 topics:

- **New Birth:** Ethical living flows from a regenerated heart.
- **Spiritual Disciplines:** Practices like prayer and meditation form moral sensitivity.
- **Discipleship Foundations:** Ethics is the visible proof of obedience and Christlike transformation.

In essence, ethics is the bridge between inner spiritual life and external ministry effectiveness.

Summary

Christian ethics and character are the tangible fruit of discipleship, the visible evidence of spiritual transformation, and the foundation for godly leadership. They require consistent practice, intentional formation, Spirit-led empowerment, and relational accountability.

A disciple grounded in ethics and character embodies Christ's love, justice, and integrity, influences communities positively, and sustains ministry effectiveness. Within EDC, these principles are actively applied in training, mentorship, evaluation, and ministry practice, ensuring that leaders and disciples are both holy and effective.

Signed:

By Discp. Samuel Ojo

EDC Rector